subsequent days, but efforts to mold the sangha into a pro-government entity were for the most part unsuccessful.

After the failure of the regime to reply, the ABMA started the excommunication process on September 17. Rallying calls by the ABMA were met with enthusiastic support for the sangha as further protests were announced. Initial protests were allowed to occur with little or no government interference. On September 18, approximately 300 monks gathered at the Shwedagon pagoda in Yangon. The significance of the location (a historical focal point of opposition) led the tatmadaw to block the protesters who moved to the downtown area. When the monks moved to gather at the Sule pagoda the government forces did not intervene. Several hundred citizens joined in the protests at this point. By this time, the authorities were starting to document, photograph, and videotape the protest activities.

Protests were occurring in numerous cities, such as Pegu, where over 1,000 monks protested. In Sittwe, monks protested calling for a lowering of the price of commodities. By the end of the day, lay people had joined with monks as the crowd swelled to over 10,000. Sporadic violence broke out and onlookers documented some police brutality.

During the next 48 hours the protesters did not encounter police brutality, but plainclothes officers videotaped the majority of protest activities. It was apparent to the regime that the protests were becoming more widespread with activities in Sittwe, Prome, and Mandalay. The uncertainty on the part of the security apparatus is difficult to explain. The authorities may have been taken by surprise or the authorities may have believed that the protests would die down after a few days. What is known is that momentum was building on the side of the resistance as the numbers swelled nationwide. As students joined the monks, it was clearly stated that if they were to be involved in the protest it was to continue in a peaceful manner.

September 22 saw a significant shift in the movement. As the protests were rapidly growing, a group of monks made it through barricades around the house of Aung San Suu Kyi. The steel gate to enter her courtyard was opened and she was allowed to greet the protesters from behind a cordon of police guards with riot shields. The image of “the lady” tearing up as protesters chanted the *metta sutta* Buddhist prayers was probably the high